

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Construction and Architecture English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For architects, construction managers, project engineers, site supervisors, estimators, owners' representatives, subcontractor coordinators, and design-build teams.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Design Intent and Client Requirements

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Drawings, Specifications, and RFIs

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

03 Change Orders and Cost Control

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

04 Schedule, Sequencing, and Critical Path

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

05 Site Safety and Toolbox Talks

Clarify missing information before responding.

06 Permitting, Inspections, and Code Issues

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Quality, Punch List, and Closeout

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

08 Claims, Disputes, and Documentation

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Design Intent and Client Requirements

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A client describes a meeting space as "flexible" but has not specified occupancy, furniture changes, or audiovisual needs.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: design intent, program, constructability, scope.

Model response

What activities should the space support, and how often will the layout change? Let's clarify occupancy and equipment needs so the design brief gives the team a usable direction.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Flexible for which activities? - Fictional design briefing: a client requests a flexible meeting room but has not specified occupancy, furniture changes, or audiovisual requirements.
2. Accessible to whom, for what use? - Separate fictional early-design case: a museum client requests an accessible staff workshop; detailed user requirements and specialist review are not yet available.

3. Open plan does not mean no storage - Separate fictional office brief: a client wants an open-plan reception area; storage quantity and privacy needs remain unspecified.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A robust finish needs a use case

A fictional community center brief asks for a robust lobby finish. The lobby receives wheeled deliveries twice weekly, but cleaning methods and appearance preferences are unknown. Clarify what the client means before selecting materials.

Role A: Architect: ask about the intended performance and missing maintenance requirements.

Role B: Facilities coordinator: confirm the delivery use and agree to obtain cleaning information.

Possible opening: When you say robust, which types of wear should the lobby finish be designed to accommodate?

Success checks

- Use the known delivery activity to focus the questions.
- Identify missing maintenance information.
- Avoid presenting an unreviewed material as the final design.

Add a complication: The coordinator asks you to name a final material before maintenance requirements are known.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Drawings, Specifications, and RFIs

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A drawing and specification appear to describe different finishes for the same area. The site team needs a documented clarification.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: RFI, specification, drawing set, submittal.

Model response

Could the design team confirm the intended finish and relevant revision? I'll identify the conflicting references in a request for information rather than assume which instruction takes precedence.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Two finish descriptions for one corridor - Fictional project coordination: drawing A14 and specification section F2 describe different corridor finishes; neither precedence nor a final selection is established.
2. The submittal refers to a missing revision - Separate fictional case: a product submittal cites drawing revision C, while the coordination folder contains only revision B; procurement has not been authorized.

3. Request a dimension without inventing one - Separate fictional coordination case: a joinery drawing omits a counter dimension needed for a shop-drawing review; no site measurement is supplied.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A finish sample has no room reference

A fictional finish sample is labeled approved color but gives no room or drawing reference. Two rooms have different scheduled colors. Ask the design coordinator to identify the intended location before the sample is used for a submittal.

Role A: Site administrator: identify the sample's missing location reference and its effect on review.

Role B: Design coordinator: agree to check the approval record rather than guess the room.

Possible opening: Could you confirm which room this approved-color sample belongs to before we use it in the submittal?

Success checks

- Name the missing room and document link.
- Explain why the distinction affects the submittal.
- Keep both room selections unaltered pending clarification.

Add a complication: The subcontractor wants to use it in both rooms to avoid waiting.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Change Orders and Cost Control

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A client requests an additional partition after pricing is agreed. Cost and schedule effects have not been assessed.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: change order, allowance, contingency, notice.

Model response

We can review the partition as a proposed change. Let's assess its cost and schedule effect through the agreed change process before confirming that it is included in the current price.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. B - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. A - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 · Conversations

1. Price the partition before promising it - Fictional change discussion: a client requests an extra partition after pricing is agreed; cost and schedule effects are unassessed.
2. An allowance is not a fixed supplier quote - Separate fictional case: a lobby project has a lighting allowance, and a client proposes a fixture that has not been quoted or reviewed.

3. A phased change needs defined boundaries - Separate fictional case: a client requests repainting three additional rooms; the contractor can assess all three together or assess one priority room first. No extra work is approved.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Add a presentation, not an entire redesign

A fictional architecture client requests a second stakeholder presentation outside the agreed one-presentation scope. The team can assess a repeat of existing material or a revised presentation, but no extra fee or date is approved. Negotiate which option to assess.

Role A: Design project manager: distinguish repeating material from creating new design content.

Role B: Client coordinator: choose a proposal and identify the approval still required.

Possible opening: We can assess a repeat presentation or a revised version; the extra scope and timing still need agreement.

Success checks

- Define the two different scopes.
- Identify the added layout request as a further change.
- Keep fees, dates, and authorization conditional on review.

Add a complication: The client asks for new layout options as part of the repeat presentation.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Schedule, Sequencing, and Critical Path

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A delivery delay affects a task on the current critical path. A lookahead schedule still shows the original sequence.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: critical path, float, lookahead schedule, resequencing.

Model response

The delayed delivery affects a critical-path task. I'll update the lookahead and show the feasible resequencing options for review instead of leaving the original dates unexplained.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. A - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. C - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. The lookahead still shows the old delivery - Fictional scheduling exercise: a delayed delivery affects a task on the current critical path; the lookahead has not been updated and recovery options are unassessed.
2. Available float is not approved resequencing - Separate fictional project case: a planner identifies two days of float on an internal finish task; a proposed resequence still needs coordination review.

3. Delivered material, unfinished readiness check - Separate fictional case: ceiling panels have arrived, but the area-readiness review for their scheduled task remains open.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A meeting milestone is complete, decisions are not

A fictional coordination meeting has taken place, but two sequencing decisions remain unresolved. The lookahead marks the milestone coordination complete. Give an update explaining the distinction and agree who follows up the decisions.

Role A: Planner: separate the completed meeting from the open sequencing decisions.

Role B: Project manager: ask how the open decisions affect the next schedule update.

Possible opening: The coordination meeting is complete, but two sequencing decisions are still open.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the completed meeting.
- Identify decisions rather than attendance as the remaining work.
- Agree follow-up ownership without inventing a recovery date.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to keep the overall complete label because everyone attended.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Site Safety and Toolbox Talks

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

In a toolbox-talk exercise, an instruction says to use "the right protection" without identifying the task or approved requirement.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: PPE, fall protection, toolbox talk, stop work.

Model response

Which task and approved safety requirement does this refer to? Please have the authorized person clarify the instruction before work proceeds. The language needs to be specific enough to understand and check.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Which task and approved protection? - Fictional toolbox-talk language exercise: an instruction says use the right protection but identifies neither the task nor its approved requirements; no actual safety method is supplied.
2. A protection abbreviation without an explanation - Separate fictional induction exercise: a briefing card contains an unexplained PPE abbreviation; trainees have not been given the task-specific approved instructions.

3. A changed task needs a clarified briefing - Separate fictional communication exercise: a supervisor's message changes the named work area but repeats an earlier generic protection instruction; actual work follows authorized procedures.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The briefing says nearby work

In a fictional toolbox-talk exercise, a notice says nearby work may affect access but names neither the location nor the responsible contact. Ask for those details. No route, protective equipment, or operating method is supplied.

Role A: Site coordinator: identify the missing location and contact before relaying the notice.

Role B: Briefing lead: agree to obtain the authorized clarification without inventing an access route.

Possible opening: Could you clarify where nearby work is taking place and who can explain the approved access arrangements?

Success checks

- Ask precise location and ownership questions.
- Do not recommend an unverified route.
- Keep actual access decisions with the authorized process.

Add a complication: A colleague offers an unofficial shortcut as the solution.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Permitting, Inspections, and Code Issues

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

An inspection note identifies outstanding items, but a progress email says the area is fully approved.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: permit, inspection, code compliance, reinspection.

Model response

Could you confirm the inspection status and the items still outstanding? I'll correct the progress wording so it does not imply approval that has not been documented.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Correct the approval claim - Fictional inspection coordination: an inspection note lists outstanding items, but a progress email says the area is fully approved.
2. A permit application needs a status source - Separate fictional project case: a permit application has been submitted; the team lacks a current status response and must request one.

3. Ask what closes the inspection item - Separate fictional closeout case: a photograph is uploaded against an inspection item, but no reviewer acceptance is recorded.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Which inspection area does the notice cover?

A fictional inspection notice names Level 2 but gives no room range. Two separate Level 2 areas are in the project. Ask the inspection liaison to confirm the covered area before coordinating attendance.

Role A: Site coordinator: request the exact inspection boundary and supporting reference.

Role B: Inspection liaison: agree to verify the notice's scope with the authorized source.

Possible opening: Could you confirm which Level 2 area this inspection notice covers so we invite the right team?

Success checks

- Identify the ambiguous area reference.
- Connect the request to attendance coordination.
- Avoid predicting approval or extending the inspection scope.

Add a complication: A manager suggests announcing that both areas will be approved after the visit.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Quality, Punch List, and Closeout

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

A closeout list contains eight items, with three completed and five awaiting review. The incoming coordinator needs the supporting records.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: punch list, substantial completion, warranty, closeout.

Model response

Three items are complete, and five await review. The list links each item to its record and responsible party. Please confirm the remaining review steps before reporting closeout as finished.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. A - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. C - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

05 • Conversations

1. Three complete, five awaiting review - Fictional closeout handoff: a punch list contains eight items, three completed and five awaiting review; the incoming coordinator needs the supporting records.

2. Warranty documents still need checking - Separate fictional handoff: equipment manuals are received, but two warranty documents lack matching equipment references; no warranty interpretation is supplied.

3. A rejected handoff needs reassignment - Separate fictional closeout case: a quality coordinator cannot accept five review follow-ups because they are leaving the project; the project manager must arrange ownership.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | One closeout link is broken

A fictional closeout register lists four accepted items, but one supporting-record link no longer opens. Acceptance is recorded; the evidence copy must be retrieved. Hand over retrieval without assuming the work must be redone or the evidence never existed.

Role A: Outgoing administrator: state the recorded acceptance and inaccessible link separately.

Role B: Incoming coordinator: accept retrieval and confirm the document reference to investigate.

Possible opening: Acceptance is recorded for this item, but its supporting-record link is unavailable and needs retrieval.

Success checks

- Separate work status from document availability.
- Avoid unsupported conclusions about missing evidence.
- Confirm who owns retrieval and the next status update.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to erase the accepted status solely because the link is broken.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Claims, Disputes, and Documentation

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A project team wants to say a delay automatically entitles it to compensation. The contract and records have not been reviewed.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: claim, daily report, meeting minutes, entitlement.

Model response

The delay and its effects should be documented, but entitlement requires appropriate contract and legal review. I'll separate the factual record from any conclusion about a claim.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. A delay does not establish entitlement - Fictional project discussion: a delay is recorded, but the contract and supporting records have not been reviewed for compensation entitlement.
2. Meeting attendance is not agreement - Separate fictional dispute case: meeting minutes record discussion of a proposed delay allocation but no explicit acceptance; a manager calls it an agreed settlement.

3. Missing daily reports limit the timeline - Separate fictional claims review: daily reports exist for Monday and Wednesday, but Tuesday's report is unavailable; the team is reconstructing a delay chronology.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A cost estimate is not an awarded claim

A fictional project team estimates disruption costs at 12,000 units. The calculation has not been reviewed and no claim has been accepted. Explain the status in a meeting with the project director.

Role A: Commercial analyst: distinguish an estimated amount from verified loss and established entitlement.

Role B: Project director: ask what evidence and review are needed before discussing recovery.

Possible opening: The 12,000 figure is an unreviewed estimate, not an accepted claim or guaranteed recovery.

Success checks

- Label the figure as an unreviewed estimate.
- Separate calculation, entitlement, and recovery.
- Agree a qualified review without predicting its outcome.

Add a complication: The director wants to include the amount as confirmed incoming funds in a project slide.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.